business and keep on spending money without a formal budget. Meanwhile, Congress, posturing and playing cynical games with the truth, blamed the White House for the deficit, and at the same time slipped costly gifts for special interests into these makeshift spending resolutions, preventing any real progress in cutting the deficit.

When one of these spending resolutions would go through Congress, it would be a foot thick and fourteen hundred pages long. (I once sprained a finger picking up one of these hefty budget resolutions.) I don't believe any congressman on Capitol Hill ever reads all those fourteen hundred pages. The press, which tries to keep an eye on everything in Washington, seldom digs deeply into the process. Yet there are things contained in these budget resolutions that cost taxpayers billions.

Congress put virtually every one of the budgets I drafted on the shelf and sent me a continuing resolution. If I had vetoed it, the government wouldn't have been able to write a paycheck or a Social Security check. The whole government might have ground to a halt, and the baby would have gone out with the bath water. So, they'd have me. I'd have to sign the next continuing resolution and, as a result, I never got the things we were asking for with regard to major cuts in spending and I wasn't able to persuade Congress to balance the budget.

I don't think we'll solve the problem of the deficit until three things happen: We need more discipline on spending in Congress. We need a constitutional amendment *requiring* Congress to balance the budget. And we need to give our presidents a line-item veto.

I think the first American to favor a balanced-federal-budget amendment was the founder of the Democratic Party, Thomas Jefferson. After the Constitutional Convention was over and the Constitution was approved, signed, and ratified, he pointed out a glaring omission: There was no